New York: The Donor Class vs the Electorate — by Party-of-Record and Age

> ▯ **SUPERSEDED BY THE PAPER'S FEDERAL PANEL (2026-07-27).** This document describes a **pooled** NY match of **308,032** voters that was, in fact, FEC-money-only — it predated `scripts/load_ny_contributions.py`, so no NYSBOE state contribution ever reached it. Two things have since changed: the NY pooled table now genuinely pools both money systems (**558,017** voters), and the match specification changed to the full-first-name key alone. Neither the counts nor the party/age tables below survive either change.
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> **Use `donor-class-and-the-electorate.md` Finding 3 instead.** It reports NY as two separate panels on the current specification — federal **269,218** donors, state **378,383** — with the party skew measured against an ACTIVE-registrant baseline (federal DEM **+16.1**, NOPARTY **−13.7**). Current figures for every panel are in `reference/primary_spec_figures_2026-07-27.md`.
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> This file is kept only as a record of the earlier analysis. Do not cite its numbers.

Party-resolved donor-class analysis, 2026-06-29. The NY counterpart of the WA §F donor findings (donor-class ≠ electorate; whale concentration). New York's individual party enrollment lets us ask which registered voters become federal donors, and how that donor class compares to the people who actually vote.

Method. Reuses the production WA matcher `match_voters_to_donors` (4 tiers, strictest first: full-name+zip5 / first-initial+middle+zip5 / first-initial+zip5 / zip3+middle, each with a per-key uniqueness guard so siblings aren't mis-merged) — pointed at NY: - voters: `data/ny_vrdb.duckdb` `voters` (12.45M **active**; party + DOB), - donors: `data/ny_statewide.duckdb` `individual_contributions` (10.02M FEC itemized individual rows, cycles 2018–2026), - output: `voter_donor_affiliation`.

Reproduce.

```
STATE=NY python scripts/match_ny_voters_to_donors.py
```

Match result. 308,032 registered NY voters matched to **6,311,939** contributions. Tier mix: full-name+zip5 **269,396** (87%, the dominant tier, as in WA), zip5 29,302, zip3+middle 5,432, zip5+middle 3,902.

Scope caveats. (1) Federal **itemized** donors only (sub-$200 unitemized giving is invisible; state/local PDC-equivalent giving not included). (2) **Active**-roll voters only (matches WA methodology for cross-state comparability). (3) Conservative name+zip join — a floor, not a census, of the donor population. (4) §1–§3 use the donor's **own NY party enrollment** (100% present); the recipient-lean cut (§4) covers the **79%** of contributions whose recipient party is resolved (see backfill note below).

Recipient-party backfill (2026-06-29). `individual_contributions .fec_candidate_id` holds the recipient **committee** id (e.g. C00211318), and NY had no committee→party map (`candidate_finance.party` ~96% Unknown, `committee_party_override` empty). `scripts/backfill_ny_committee_party.py` runs the bulk FEC **Committee Master** loader (`load_fec_committee_master`, `cm{yy}.zip` per cycle → committee-id-keyed `candidate_finance` rows) + the conduit-PAC overrides, then resolves remaining candidate committees via the candidate master (`cn{yy}.zip`, committee→candidate→party). D/R-resolved contribution share went **0.5%** → **79.0%**. The unresolved 21% are genuinely-nonpartisan / unaffiliated PACs.

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1. The donor class is disproportionately Democratic — and the unaffiliated are nearly absent

Share of matched donors and matched dollars by the donor's **own** NY enrollment, vs the registration baseline:

party	donors	donor share	registration	skew	$ (matched)	$ share
DEM	193,355	62.8%	47.8%	**+15.0**	$849.2M	71.0%
REP	65,898	21.4%	22.3%	−0.9	$197.2M	16.5%
NOPARTY (blank)	38,601	12.5%	25.5%	**−13.0**	$126.8M	10.6%

party	donors	donor share	registration	skew	$ (matched)	$ share
OTHER (minor)	10,178	3.3%	4.4%	−1.1	$22.8M	1.9%

Finding. The federal donor class over-represents registered Democrats (+15 pts vs their share of the roll) and **severely under-represents the unaffiliated** — NY's "blank" enrollees are a quarter of all registrants but only an eighth of donors (−13 pts). Republicans donate roughly in proportion to their registration. Democrats supply **71% of matched dollars**. The donor class is not a scaled-down electorate; it is a partisan-skewed slice of it — and the skew runs *against* the largest non-partisan bloc.

2. The donor class is far older than even the (already-gray) electorate

Age-band share (age as of 2024-11-05) among matched donors vs all active voters vs 2024 general-election voters:

age band	matched donors	all active voters	2024 GE voters
18-29	**3.0%**	18.0%	14.1%
30-44	14.2%	25.6%	23.1%
45-64	34.9%	31.2%	34.6%
65+	**47.9%**	25.2%	28.2%

Finding. Donors skew dramatically old: **nearly half (48%) of matched donors are 65+**, versus 25% of the active roll and 28% of 2024 voters; under-30s are 3% of donors versus 14–18% elsewhere. The donor class is older than the off-year electorate that the turnout study already flagged as gray — a *second*, compounding age distortion layered on top of who turns out.

Match-bias validation (`scripts/diag_ny_match_bias.py` *).* The skew is **not** a matching artifact. P(matchable) — the share of active voters whose Tier-0 key (last, full first, zip5) is unique on the roll — is **94.5–95.4% across every age band** (0.9-pt spread). Re-weighting the donor age distribution by 1/P(matchable) moves the 65+ share by **0.0 pts** (47.9% → 47.9%). Older voters are not meaningfully more matchable, so the donor age skew is genuine — replicating the WA §F result.

3. Whale concentration — replicates WA almost exactly

Among matched NY donors: - **top 1% of donors = 51.2% of matched dollars** - **top 10% of donors = 81.2% of matched dollars**

This tracked the WA finding (pooled top 1% ≈ 46.6% of matched $ on the current specification) — donor money is whale-dominated to nearly the same degree in a much larger, bluer state, suggesting the concentration is structural to federal small-vs-large-dollar giving rather than state-specific.

4. Where the money goes — recipient lean and crossover

Among matched donors whose recipient party is resolved, the share of each **own-party** group's donations going to Democratic vs Republican recipients:

own party	donors (resolved)	→ Democratic	→ Republican	mixed
DEM	174,330	**94.2%**	3.9%	1.9%
REP	57,342	14.2%	**82.6%**	3.2%
NOPARTY (blank)	30,590	**65.5%**	31.0%	3.5%
OTHER (minor)	8,274	40.7%	57.0%	2.3%

Findings. (1) Registered Democrats are near-monolithic givers (94% to D); registered Republicans are loyal but leakier (83% to R) — **registered Republicans fund Democrats at ~3.6× the rate Democrats fund Republicans** (14.2% vs 3.9%), consistent with a deep-blue donor ecosystem. (2) The crucial unaffiliated bloc — invisible to registration-based targeting — **leans ~2:1 Democratic in its giving** (65.5% → D), so NY's "blank" donors are not centrist by behavior. (3) Minor-party

(OTHER) registrants lean Republican (57%), consistent with Conservative-line enrollment.

Why this matters (electoral-health framing)

Combined with the turnout paper, NY now shows **two stacked filters** between the registered population and political influence: (1) an older, party-asymmetric *voting* electorate, and (2) an even older, more-Democratic, whale-concentrated *donor* class from which the unaffiliated quarter of the state is largely missing. Each is measured with individual party-of-record — the evidence WA could not supply. This is the donor-class half of the party-resolved §F playbook.

Open follow-ons: (1) ~~recipient-party backfill~~ — **DONE** (§4; 79% resolved via the bulk committee/candidate masters); (2) ~~match-bias re-weighting~~ — **DONE** (§2 validation note; skew genuine, 0.0-pt shift); (3) fold §1–§4 into the cross-state "Donor Class" paper (publication sequence #3).